Under Gandhi's leadership, the Indian national movement embraced moral ideals, which in turn have led to the emergence of a sense of Indian exceptionalism – that India is unique, special and an example for the rest of the world. The very first resolution passed by the Constituent Assembly of India on 13 December 1946 stated: 'This ancient land attains its rightful and honoured place in the world and makes its full and willing contribution to the promotion of world peace and the welfare of mankind.'[9] An anonymous article in the July 1949 issue of *Foreign Affairs* described India as 'an infant state' that was 'no newcomer to history, no offshoot or colony newly risen to nationhood'.[10]

In the decades immediately after Independence, this desire to be seen as a global leader, albeit a moral one, often amplified the preaching overtones of Indian foreign policy. India's championing of anti-colonialism and anti-racism and its campaign against apartheid in South Africa were part of this policy. So was India's demand for reforms not only in the United Nations Security Council but also in the international economic order, including the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank. India saw the world's major powers, especially the industrialized capitalist nations, as unwilling to cater to the interests of previously colonized poorer countries. India's leading role in the creation of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), the Group of 77 (G-77) and BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) represents its effort to create international institutions that are not run by western European powers or the United States of America.



Lacking resources to participate in the cold war and fearing that participation would tear the fragile nation apart, India's leaders sought to stay away from military alliances and adopted what they insisted was a non-aligned path. Non-alignment was different from neutrality as it did not imply a refusal to take positions in global conflicts. It was simply a refusal